

Heart Attack: recognize and act

Most heart attacks start slowly, with mild pain or discomfort, while others are sudden and intense. It is crucial to understand that symptoms can vary widely between individuals, and many people do not experience the classic crushing chest pain. Every minute counts — acting quickly is vital.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

A heart attack is a medical emergency — call immediately

If you or someone else might be having a heart attack, call your local emergency number (examples: 911, 112, or 999; verify locally) right away. Do not wait to see if symptoms go away. Emergency medical responders can begin treatment on the way to the hospital and ensure you are taken to a specialized cardiac care center.

Recognize the signs of a heart attack

1. **Chest discomfort.** Most heart attacks involve discomfort in the center of the chest that lasts more than a few minutes, or that goes away and comes back. It can feel like uncomfortable pressure, squeezing, fullness, or pain.
2. **Discomfort in other upper-body areas.** Symptoms can include pain or discomfort in one or both arms, the back, neck, jaw, or stomach.
3. **Shortness of breath.** This can happen with or without chest discomfort, sometimes as the only symptom.
4. **Other signs.** These may include breaking out in a cold sweat, feeling lightheaded or dizzy, or experiencing unexplained nausea or vomiting.

SYMPTOMS CAN BE DIFFERENT FOR WOMEN

Like men, women's most common heart attack symptom is chest pain or discomfort. However, women are somewhat more likely than men to experience other common symptoms, particularly shortness of breath, nausea, vomiting, and back or jaw pain, without any chest pressure or pain. Do not ignore these subtler signs.

What to do while you wait for medical help

KEEP THEM CALM AND COMFORTABLE

- **Sit down, rest, and stay calm.** Do not allow the person to walk, climb stairs, or exert themselves, as physical effort increases the strain on the heart.
- **Chew and swallow an aspirin.** If the person is not allergic to aspirin, has no history of severe bleeding, and has not been told by a doctor not to take aspirin, have them chew and swallow one adult aspirin (325 mg) or 2 to 4 low-dose baby aspirins (81 mg each). Chewing the tablet helps it absorb faster into the bloodstream to reduce clotting.
- **Loosen tight clothing.** Unbutton collars, loosen belts, and make sure their airway is completely clear.
- **Stay with them.** Reassure them continuously. Keep them sitting comfortably to help them breathe more easily.
- **Be ready to start CPR.** If the person becomes unresponsive and is not breathing normally, start Hands-Only CPR immediately. Put the phone on speaker and follow dispatcher instructions.

WHAT NOT TO DO

- **Do not drive yourself or the patient to the hospital.** Paramedics are trained to start life-saving treatments immediately. Driving yourself is dangerous if you lose consciousness, and taking a private car may delay treatment at the hospital entrance compared to arrival by ambulance.
- **Do not ignore the symptoms.** Many people delay seeking help because they hope it is only indigestion or muscle strain. Seeking treatment early limits heart muscle damage.
- **Do not try “cough CPR.”** Coughing repeatedly and vigorously is a dangerous internet myth. It does not prevent or treat a heart attack and should not be used.

Lower your risk

- Monitor and control high blood pressure, high cholesterol, and diabetes under a clinician's care.
- Avoid smoking and limit alcohol consumption to low-risk levels.
- Maintain a healthy weight, eat a heart-healthy diet, and stay physically active.
- Understand your family medical history and discuss your cardiovascular risk factors with a doctor.

Sources

- American Heart Association (AHA) — Heart Attack Symptoms and Warning Signs.
- U.S. CDC — Heart Attack Symptoms and Risk Factors.
- National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (NHLBI) — Heart Attack.
- British Heart Foundation (BHF) — Heart Attack Symptoms and Action Guide.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number without delay. Reuse and reprint freely.